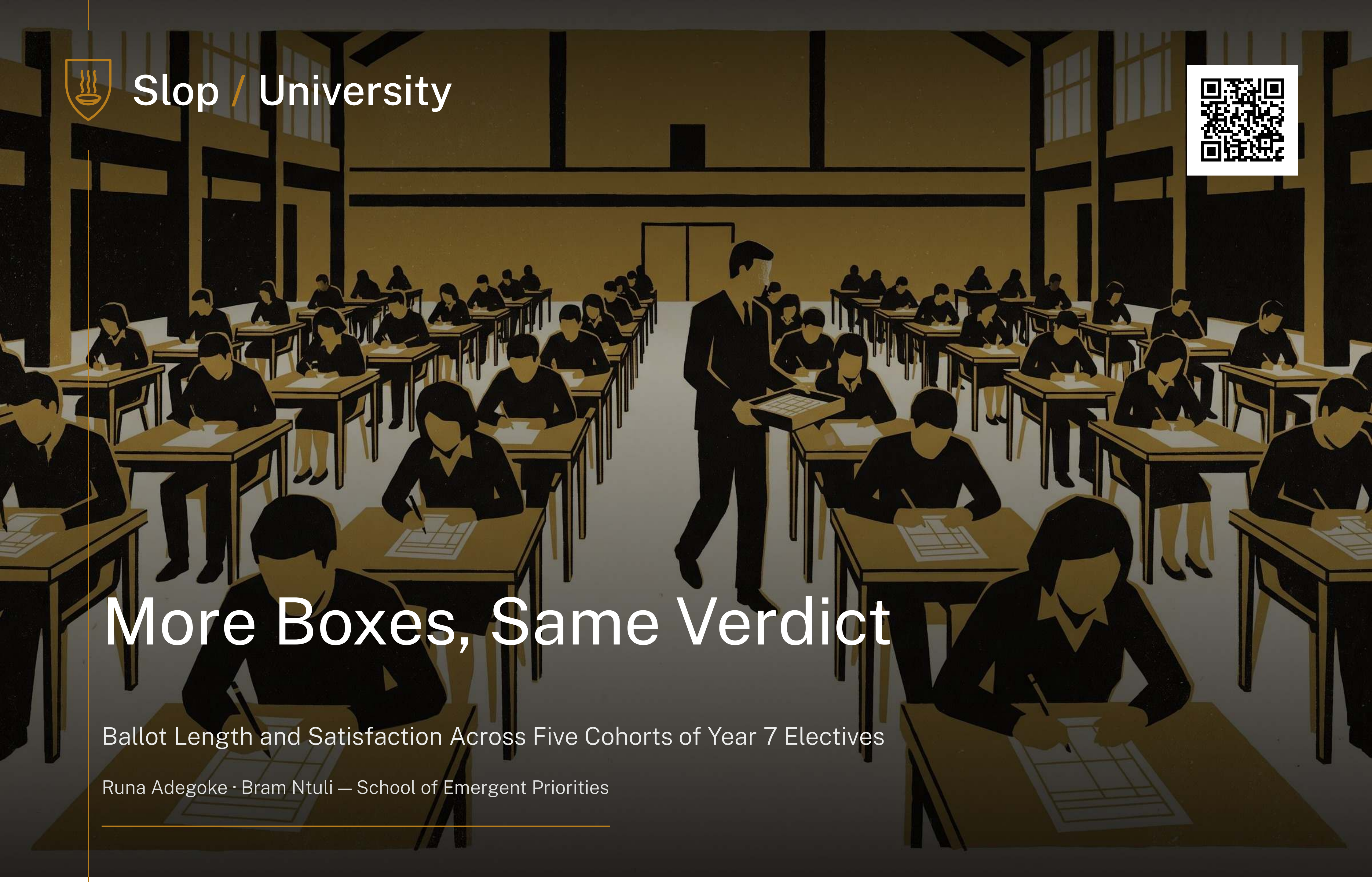

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More Boxes, Same Verdict

Ballot Length and Satisfaction Across Five Cohorts of Year 7 Electives

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Background

Every Year 7 timetable begins with a ranked ballot, and every school assumes a longer form gives the allocation algorithm more to work with. Five years into an expanded ballot, nobody had checked whether the extra ranked choices change what students actually receive.

Aims

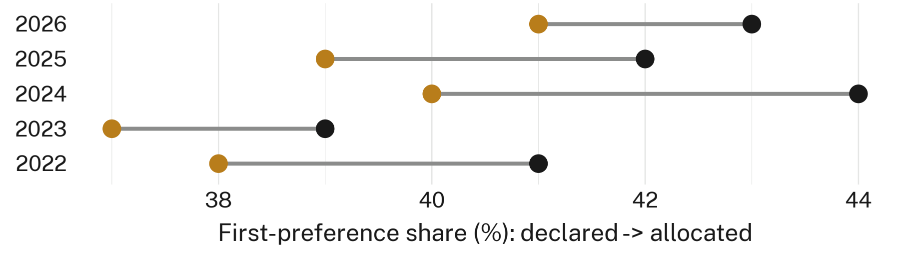
- Compare post-allocation satisfaction between 3-choice and 5-choice ballot cohorts
- Test whether ballot length shifts the share of students placed in their declared first preference
- Establish whether the declared-to-allocated gap narrows once more choices are collected

Methods

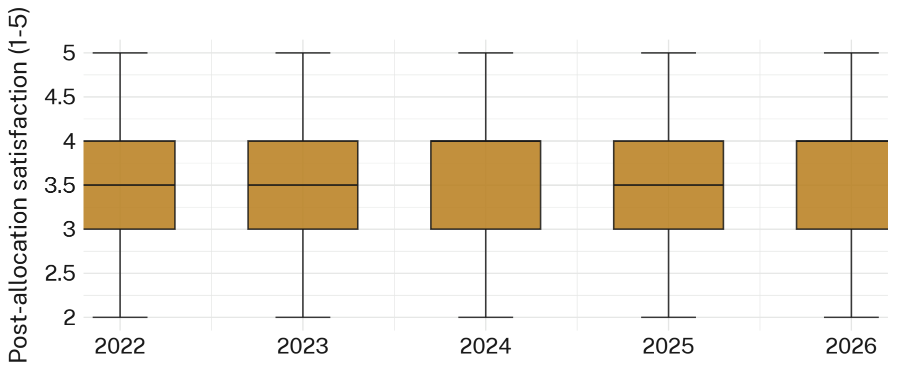
- n = 612 Year 7 students across five intake cohorts (2022–2026) · self-report survey · 4-week post-allocation window
- Ballot length rolled by cohort: 3-choice through 2023, 5-choice from 2024 · allocation algorithm and seat caps held constant throughout
- Satisfaction on a pre-registered 5-point instrument; declared and allocated first preferences logged from the enrolment system

Results

Post-allocation satisfaction is statistically indistinguishable between 3-choice ($M = 3.41/5$) and 5-choice ($M = 3.38/5$) cohorts ($t(610) = 0.44$, $p = .66$). The extra ranked boxes reorder which subject becomes the second-preference disappointment; they do not change how many students get it.



First-preference allocation share held between 37% and 41% across all five cohorts (2022–2026); the 2024 ballot-length change produced no measurable shift (Δ = 0.6 pp, n.s.).



Satisfaction quartiles overlap fully across all five cohorts; the 2024 ballot-length change moves neither the median nor the spread.

Discussion & conclusions

Ballot length changes what students are asked, not what they get: the declared-to-allocated gap holds within a point of its five-year mean regardless of form. A widely trusted proxy for student voice moves the paperwork, not the seat, and the satisfaction distribution above shows why — whatever a longer ballot changes about the ranking exercise, it leaves the lived experience of the timetable untouched. Next: trial disclosing seat caps before ranking, rather than after.

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We thank the participating schools' enrolment offices for retrieving five years of ballot archives. Ballots and satisfaction responses de-identified before analysis; no student contacted directly.

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